

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

without formal training in personal finance. Dig deeper, and many financial planning concepts are heavily borrowed from the West, with much of it feeling distant from Indian households. Joint families and multi-generational households are common in India, but don't really fit in the West. Very little effort has gone into making personal finance relatable to India. We have tried to adapt a very western approach to financial life, with mixed results.

↘ Budget Fixation

Every finance expert insists on a budget being the foundation of a sound financial life. There is no doubt about the advantages of following a budget. However, when expense categories change so often because of rising prices, budgets that focus on setting spending limits or allocating funds can feel restrictive. Sticking to a budget is like sticking to a diet, which is extremely difficult to follow. Like diets, life on a budget also fails, and you spiral into the unwanted.

MONTH-TO-MONTH SURVIVAL IS MAKING PEOPLE CUT INTO EVEN ESSENTIALS IN MANY CASES, IMPACTING THEIR MENTAL HEALTH AND PEACE OF MIND

Ideally, managing your money should feel simple, fun and easy, regardless of your financial circumstances. The cash-flow system should let you track inflows and outflows, and manage the surplus into investments. For a youngster, the choice of investment could be to enhance their life skills or learn something that can improve their future income stream. Money is a means, not the end goal. Think of